when Daniyal marched into Khandesh, Bahadur declined to come and greet him. Abul Fazl tried to negotiate with the new king, but had no luck. Bahadur had shut himself up in the towering fortress of Asirgarh, and he would have no further truck with the Mughal empire, no matter if it was breathing down his neck.

It was from this failed meeting that Abul Fazl rode on to greet Akbar. The emperor had missed his scribe, it seems; he greeted him with a cordial verse: ‘Serene be the night and pleasant the moonshine / That I may talk with thee on every subject.’[10]

There was much to talk about. Murad’s death, of course, Salim’s unwillingness to go to war, Daniyal’s lack of enterprise. Or perhaps Akbar did not linger on the subject of his sons. Perhaps he was happy to be out on a campaign again, after such a long time, amid soldiers and bellowing elephants, with yet another grand fortress to conquer.

‘Old soldiers, and men who had travelled into distant lands – men who had seen the fortresses of Iran and Turan, of Rum, Europe, and of the whole habitable world, had never beheld the equal of this.’[11] Asirgarh – massive, monstrous, built in three stages upon a high hill, its walls often indistinguishable from the rocks – would be the final test of Akbar’s fortune in war, and one of the glories of Abul Fazl’s brief military career.

Of course, at fifty-eight, Akbar would not be standing in the smoke and blaze of a siege, shooting the enemy down with his guns. He had travelled with a full court, including the latest mission of Jesuit Fathers, his harem and grandchildren, amongst them Salim’s eldest boy and the emperor’s favourite, Khusro. The emperor settled 25 kilometres south of Asirgarh, in a town called Burhanpur, which would become the Mughals’ Dakkan ka Darwaza, their headquarters in the Deccan. From here, Akbar would contribute to the war effort with prayer and prophecy.

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Akbar ‘engaged in special acts of devotion, and took to repeating the Great Name’, writes Abul Fazl, whose duty it was to send the emperor halwa after each such session. Over the long months in which Abul Fazl and his colleagues undertook the siege of Asirgarh, Akbar spent long hours calling to God. He was following a custom, writes Henry Beveridge, in which the